When the Sea Turns Cold, Rescuers Rush to Save Sea Turtles

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On a dark, chilly December afternoon in 2025, volunteer Annemarie O'Connell drove to a beach in Truro, Massachusetts, near the tip of Cape Cod, with a flashlight in hand. She was looking for sea turtles that had washed ashore, too cold to swim.

Like other reptiles, most sea turtles cannot make their own body heat. They stay comfortable in water between about 17 and 29 degrees Celsius (62 to 85 degrees Fahrenheit). In summer, warming seas draw many turtles north. In fall and winter, they head back south toward the **tropics**.

But if the water drops below 10 degrees Celsius (50 degrees Fahrenheit) before they move on, turtles can get too cold. They weaken and slow down, with less energy to dive and feed. It is also harder for their bodies to fight off infections. Some stop swimming and drift at the surface. This condition, called **cold stunning**, leaves turtles **dazed** and numb.

Every winter, hundreds of cold-stunned turtles wash up on Massachusetts beaches. Many had been swimming south but could not get beyond Cape Cod. **Cold stunning** is also a problem along Gulf and Pacific coasts, where shallow water along Florida and Texas can chill quickly during cold snaps.

Government workers and **conservation** groups patrol beaches in late fall and winter, looking for cold-stunned turtles. Without help, these animals may die. But if they are moved quickly to special hospitals, many will survive. That is what brought O'Connell to the beach. Around high tide, she found a large **loggerhead** about one meter (three feet) long. 'It was huge,' she remembers, 'like a rock that had plopped out of the sky.' Its eyes were swollen shut, but when she approached, it moved its head. Helpers slid it onto a sled and drove it toward care.

Word Treasure

cold stunning -- A condition in which a sea turtle gets so cold that it becomes weak, dazed, and unable to swim.

loggerhead -- A large kind of sea turtle with a big head.

tropics -- The warm parts of the world near the equator.

conservation -- Work to protect wild animals and nature.

dazed -- Confused and unable to think or move clearly.

Background you need

Sea turtles are reptiles that cannot make their own body heat, so they depend on warm water to stay active and healthy.

In summer, warming seas draw many turtles north, and in fall and winter they head back south toward warmer waters.

If the water around them cools too much before they move on, they can become cold-stunned, growing weak, slow, and unable to dive or feed well.

People who patrol beaches in the cold months look for these stranded turtles and bring them to special hospitals where many can recover.

Break it down

LEAD: On a dark, chilly December afternoon in 2025, volunteer Annemarie O'Connell drove to a beach in Truro, Massachusetts, near the tip of Cape Cod, with a flashlight in hand, looking for sea turtles that had washed ashore, too cold to swim.

KEY EVENT: Around high tide, she found a large loggerhead about one meter (three feet) long.

+- WHO: Volunteer Annemarie O'Connell and helpers

+- WHERE: A beach in Truro, Massachusetts, near the tip of Cape Cod

+- WHEN: A dark, chilly December afternoon in 2025, around high tide

+- WHAT WAS FOUND: A large loggerhead with its eyes swollen shut that moved its head when O'Connell approached; helpers slid it onto a sled and drove it toward care

WHY TURTLES GET COLD-STUNNED: Like other reptiles, most sea turtles cannot make their own body heat.

+- COMFORTABLE RANGE: They stay comfortable in water between about 17 and 29 degrees Celsius (62 to 85 degrees Fahrenheit).

+- SEASONAL MOVEMENT: In summer, warming seas draw many turtles north, and in fall and winter they head back south toward the tropics.

+- DANGER POINT: If the water drops below 10 degrees Celsius (50 degrees Fahrenheit) before they move on, turtles can get too cold.

+- EFFECTS: They weaken and slow down, with less energy to dive and feed, it is harder for their bodies to fight off infections, and some stop swimming and drift at the surface, dazed and numb.

EVIDENCE: Every winter, hundreds of cold-stunned turtles wash up on Massachusetts beaches, many having swum south but been unable to get beyond Cape Cod; cold stunning is also a problem along Gulf and Pacific coasts, where shallow water along Florida and Texas can chill quickly during cold snaps.

RESCUE: Government workers and conservation groups patrol beaches in late fall and winter looking for cold-stunned turtles; without help, these animals may die, but if they are moved quickly to special hospitals, many will survive.

Why it matters

Warming seas draw many turtles north in summer, so a sudden drop in water temperature can leave them stranded far from the warm water they need. Quick rescue matters because, without help, cold-stunned turtles may die, while many survive if they reach special hospitals in time.

Test what you remember

1. Why can sea turtles become cold-stunned in fall and winter?

- (A) They stop eating in summer and run out of energy.
- (B) They prefer cold water and swim north to find it.
- (C) They cannot make their own body heat, and water below 10 degrees Celsius (50 degrees Fahrenheit) can leave them too cold to swim.
- (D) Their shells crack when the air turns chilly.

2. In what water temperatures do most sea turtles stay comfortable?

- (A) Between about 17 and 29 degrees Celsius (62 to 85 degrees Fahrenheit)
- (B) Below 10 degrees Celsius
- (C) Above 40 degrees Celsius
- (D) Only in water at exactly 10 degrees Celsius

3. What did Annemarie O'Connell find on the beach in Truro?

- (A) A seal with swollen eyes
- (B) A large loggerhead about one meter (three feet) long
- (C) An empty turtle nest
- (D) A small fish trapped in a rock pool

4. What happened to the loggerhead after O'Connell found it?

- (A) It was taken to a zoo for visitors to see.
- (B) Helpers slid it onto a sled and drove it toward care.
- (C) It was left on the beach to warm up on its own.
- (D) It swam back into the sea by itself.

5. Why do many cold-stunned turtles wash up on Massachusetts beaches each winter?

- (A) They follow boats that bring them to shore.
- (B) They had been swimming south but could not get beyond Cape Cod.
- (C) They are chasing food that only grows on Cape Cod beaches.
- (D) They are trying to lay eggs on Massachusetts beaches in winter.

6. What do government workers and conservation groups do in late fall and winter, and why?

- (A) They move turtles north to colder water.
- (B) They count turtles to decide when summer begins.
- (C) They close the beaches so no turtles can come ashore.
- (D) They patrol beaches looking for cold-stunned turtles, because without help these animals may die, but many survive if moved quickly to special hospitals.

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):